

Main Idea - Study Guide

Find the idea that fits the whole passage - including its limits and qualifications.

Learning goal

Identify explicit and implied central ideas, and distinguish the best answer from choices that are true but incomplete.

1. Topic, main idea, and summary are different

Term	What it means	Example
Topic	The subject	city trees
Main idea	What the text says about the subject	City trees can reduce heat, but their benefits depend on where and how they are planted.
Summary	Main idea + major supporting points	A short account that keeps the central idea and the most important developments.

2. How exam-style questions ask it

- Which statement best expresses the central idea of the passage?
- Which statement best expresses an idea developed throughout the passage?
- Which statement best states the author's main point?

3. Explicit vs. implied main idea

Explicit: the author states the main point fairly directly.

Implied: no single sentence gives the full answer. You have to combine repeated details, examples, changes, and conclusions.

4. The four-step method

1. **Name the topic.** What subject appears throughout the passage?
2. **Notice the repeated direction.** What do the important details keep showing about it?
3. **Write a one-sentence point.** Finish: "The passage mainly shows that..."
4. **Test every option against the whole text.** The best answer should fit the beginning, middle, and end.

5. Long-passage strategy: build a paragraph map

Do not memorize 700 words.

Track what each paragraph is doing in a few words: *problem* → *example* → *evidence* → *limitation* → *result*. Then ask what idea connects those paragraph jobs.

A central idea usually explains why the author included several important sections, not just one memorable paragraph.

6. When two answers both seem true

This is where harder RLA questions separate "a true statement" from "the best answer."

1. Which option explains **more of the passage**?
2. Which option keeps the author's **qualification**?
3. Which option requires **fewer assumptions**?

Example: A passage says a four-day workweek improved employee satisfaction in one pilot, while managers still need more data on busy seasons.

"Four-day schedules improve workplaces" is too broad.

"The pilot showed benefits, but the company still needs evidence about how the schedule works under different conditions" better matches the whole passage.

7. Common distractors

Trap	Why it can look right
Supporting detail	It is true, but only one piece of the larger point.
Too narrow	Covers one paragraph, example, or event.
Too broad	Makes a claim larger than the text supports.
True but incomplete	Gets one half right but misses a limitation or second major idea.
Unsupported generalization	Sounds sensible, but the passage does not provide enough evidence.

8. Worked example - implied main idea

When the town first opened a weekend farmers market, only eight vendors registered. By the end of the first summer, more than twenty sellers were attending regularly. Nearby cafes began opening earlier on market days, and the library started Saturday programs because more families were already downtown. The town later added bicycle racks and shaded seating around the square.

Which statement best expresses an idea developed throughout the passage?

- A. The farmers market became part of a wider increase in weekend activity downtown.
- B. The library is the most popular place in town on Saturdays.
- C. Bicycle racks caused more vendors to register.
- D. Every town should open a weekend farmers market.

Best answer: A. Vendor growth, cafe hours, library programs, and town improvements all point to a wider change. The other choices either use one detail, claim a cause the passage does not prove, or add a recommendation.

9. Diagnostic help

- **You choose one vivid detail:** force yourself to name what at least three paragraphs have in common.
- **You pick answers that sound smart but are too broad:** check for words such as *all*, *always*, *every*, *proves*.
- **You get stuck between two answers:** choose the one that covers more of the passage while keeping its limits.

10. Quick check

A community center replaced fluorescent lights with LEDs. The new lights use less electricity and last longer. The center paid more at the beginning, but its monthly electricity bill dropped during the first year, and staff expect fewer bulb replacements.

Which statement best expresses the central idea?

- A. LED lights are always cheaper to buy.
- B. The center expects the LED upgrade to reduce energy and maintenance costs over time.
- C. Workers dislike replacing fluorescent bulbs.
- D. The center plans to remove all older equipment.

Answer: B. It covers the higher starting cost, lower electricity use, and expected maintenance benefit.

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